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Labor Trafficking

Intro

What is the true monetary value of a human life? A taboo inquisition that not many want to think about, let alone put a number towards. Yet, the global economy has not only put a price tag to that of human life, but also regularly exercises the transactions, abuse, and dehumanization of the world's people. In fact, since the dawn of human society, practices of labor trafficking were being conducted by many developing communities. This off-putting underground economy has plagued humanity since historical times, and not only is the demand for such goods extremely inelastic, but the demand itself has also barely dropped over the past thousand years. Humanity has made its fair share of attempts to try and address these issues over recent times, yet, labor trafficking still seems as prevalent as ever.

So what exactly is going wrong? What does society need to begin looking at in order to figure out the best approaches to lessening the planet's most inhumane marketplace? Well, as with all modern issues, one must first look at human history in order to begin to understand the issue in greater detail, as learning from history is the greatest way to learn from society's previous mistakes and advance as a worldwide community. Then, dissecting this industry into what composes it and what makes it run, along with analyzing the negative externalities such as loss of societal productivity and increased social service costs is crucial as it allows society to get a better sense of the issues that labor trafficking creates along with tackling the industry by its

roots, as when a problem is not addressed by looking at the root cause, it will only allow it to grow back just as strong again over time.

One of the most important parts will then be looking at modern nations and cases, in order to see not only what society can learn from these cases, but to look at the similarities between problematic nations in today's world, allowing for solutions that directly address the issues of specific problematic nations and societies. All in all, to effectively address this issue, it is crucial for the planet to adopt a multi-faceted approach using government action, organizational collaboration, and awareness to the general public through education.

So what exactly does it mean for labor to be trafficked as opposed to just regular labor? What makes labor trafficked specifically lies in the nature of the recruitment and treatment of these laboring individuals. Whereas with regular labor, workers are willing to work and are compensated and given worker's benefits, trafficked laborers are either forced, manipulated, or coerced into taking the job. These individuals are then provided with minimum to no compensation, are put to work in inhumane conditions, and are turned into slaves with no way of returning to their previous lives.

It is important to distinguish between the two, as many people in this world may be working in what may be considered "inhumane conditions" or receiving relatively what would be considered very little compensation, but, if they are willingly working and are being compensated equivalently to what they believe they should be, then that labor is not trafficked. Rather, that individual is simply working in a third-world country with a poor economy and no workers' benefits and is simply making what they need to survive. Trafficked laborers are not *free of will*, differentiating them from an individual as described above.

History

According to the National Human Trafficking Hotline, there are approximately 25 million people trapped in forced labor, illustrating just how broad of a scope this issue still has presently. But, when exactly did this problem become so prevalent in society? In fact, this issue began right alongside the development of ancient human societies. Taking a look at Ancient Egypt, which existed at approximately 3100 BCE, trafficked labor was an integral part of this society's development and technological advancement. Taking a look at graphic 1 below, this Ancient Egyptian artwork dating back to 1390 BCE by the name "Tomb of Nebamun and Ipukyca", one could clearly see the depiction of trafficked labor being exercised by the slaves in the artwork, laboring as craftsmen for the sake of their societies ruler. In fact, in the early development of Ancient Egypt, the construction of great feats such as The Pyramids and Great Sphinx of Giza in ~2500 BCE were greatly assisted by the laboring of Ancient Egypt's slaves who worshiped and worked for the Pharaoh, building a monument so large that it would not be topped by humans until the Eiffel Tower in 1887.

Not only did the society of Ancient Egypt have typical slave labor present within their own society, but they also enslaved people from other societies. In fact, as depicted in the Old Testament, the Israelites were enslaved by the Egyptians and transported across the desert to labor in grueling jobs for the Egyptian Pharaoh, such as construction, mines and quarries, and brickmaking[1]. It is evident that ever since 3000 BCE, the world's most successful human civilizations had been heavily exercising the use of trafficked labor within their societies as it allowed for their quick and efficient advancement.

[1] Old Testament." The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. Accessed April 21, 2023.

Graphic 1: Craftsmen, Tomb of Nebamun and Ipukyca. 1390–1349 B.C. New Kingdom. Norman de Garis Davies[2]

In the near future of Ancient history with the development of Ancient Greece in ~800 BCE and Ancient Rome in ~500 BCE, trafficked labor can continue to be seen as an integral part of advancing human civilization, and developing the world we have today. During this time period, the Roman Empire was conquesting Ancient Greece, and therefore both sides were constantly at war. For this reason, quick and efficient advancement was instrumental to either side in order to be victorious. For this reason, slave labor was necessary and allowed for quick technological advancement on both ends.

These nations would get their trafficked labor from traveling merchants selling slaves or from other nations as prisoners of war, with all slaves being non-citizen foreigners (unlike Ancient Egypt)[3]. As a matter of fact, trafficked labor was so integrated within these societies, that slaves from other advanced civilizations such as Greek slaves in Rome often performed

[2] "Rethinking Slavery in the Ancient Near East." American Society of Overseas Research (ASOR), March 21, 2023.

[3] "Confronting Slavery in the Classical World." Emory. Accessed April 21, 2023.

high-skill jobs such as becoming an accountant or a doctor[4]. In this way, although different from previous societies, these prestigious ancient societies also had their foundations in that of trafficked labor, further illustrating how valuable the surplus from trafficked individuals truly is to whoever reaps that surplus.

This can further be related to something that hits closer to home, and that is the development of the United States of America from 1776 all the way into the nation it is today. Looking back at the Gold Rush Era in the 1850s, many Chinese immigrants came to California with the promise of gold and a successful life. But, in reality, this became fraud and coercion by the United States as the Chinese citizens were immediately discriminated against and exploited by these mining businesses. They were assigned to jobs that were grueling and dangerous for American citizens with little to no compensation, and according to B.A. in History Sophia Southard, the Chinese workers were given snippets of gold dust that were left in miners' dirty clothes and the wash water[5]. Not only that, in 1852 the government even began to impose a large monthly tax on all foreign miners, making their minimal compensation even lower than it already was[6].

Adjacent to these actions by the U.S. government, was also one of the country's most shameful exercising of labor trafficking in its history; slavery of Africans. But, although extremely inhumane, it was these practices that allowed this nation to become as prosperous as it is today, as it was the nation's development that reaped the surplus from slavery. Prior to and during the Civil War, as well as during WWII, labor from slavery was necessary and integral for the nation's success. In fact, the Southern U.S. was producing 60 percent of the world's cotton

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[4] "Confronting Slavery in the Classical World." Emory. Accessed April 21, 2023.

[5] Terrell, Ellen. "Chinese Americans and the Gold Rush: Inside Adams." The Library of Congress, January 28, 2021.

[6] "Chinese Immigrants and the California Gold Rush." Hickman Mills C-1 School District / Homepage. Accessed April 21, 2023.

during the Civil War times, paying for a substantial amount of capital that laid the path for American economic growth[7]. It was this labor that allowed this nation to be successful in developing new technologies and be successful in war, as they were able to maximize the amount of production of their workers in the shortest amount of time possible. Whereas legal workers have benefits and only work for so many hours a day, a slave could work 21 hours a day and produce at a much higher rate, as their life is hung over their own heads daily. Sweatshops for developing weapons and gear and clothing for soldiers were integral in defeating the Axis Powers, and this production came from no other than trafficked labor.

In this way, the United States along with essentially all modern-day prosperous societies was built on the back of trafficked labor. But why is that important to address the issue today? Well, the importance lies in the fact that trafficked labor, although no longer used by all societies, has barely changed at all since 3000 BCE all the way to the birth of the United States of America and all the way to the present day. It is still used in the same ways, and for the same reasons, by many different nations and groups/businesses/individuals throughout the world as it was 5000 years ago. It is for this reason that action must be done and humanity must learn from its history, as the costs to humanity as a whole are far greater than any benefits if this market continues to thrive globally.

Issues of labor trafficking

Opportunity cost and negative externalities

Opportunity cost is the potential forgone profit from the next opportunity. The opportunity cost of labor trafficking is huge and even causes negative externality that makes a

[7] Mintz, Steven. "The Gilder Lehrman Institute of American History." Historical Context: Was Slavery the Engine of American Economic Growth? | Gilder Lehrman Institute of American History. Accessed April 21, 2023.

third party worse off. For example, according to Global Times[8], many Chinese were trafficked to Myanmar for telecom fraud. Those Chinese could do other jobs which are more productive than telecom fraud or take education to improve themselves. So, the victims' next opportunity is much better than telecom fraud. Additionally, telecom fraud causes negative externality by swindling others' properties.

These properties ought to be used in other ways, such as donating to poor countries to help children or investing to get more value. Those can always create more utility and positive externality for society than telecom fraud. Also, when the trafficker trades workers, they create a negative externality for those workers' families, because, like human trafficking, those victims are forced to submit their passports, phones, and other personal effects, so they are secluded from the world and their families cannot contact them, and then the dysphoric mood will around the families and using lots of time and resources to find them. Overall, the costs of labor trafficking are the opportunity cost of victims and properties that have been frauded, and the negative externality created by traffickers and telecom fraud.

Child labor

Child labor is another issue. According to World's Children[9], 27% of trafficking victims are children. Kate[10] points out that child trafficking is based on distinctions of gender, age, and place. Compared to boys, girls are easier victims. 66% of child trafficking victims are girls, and most of them are forced to do sexual exploitation or be scavengers to street hawkers. From the traffickers' perspective, girls are easily controlled and make more money. The average age of trafficking is 12-15 years old[11]. Children at that age are most "useful" to the traffickers. They

[8] "Some Chinese Lured by 'High-Paying Jobs' End up in Telecom Fraud, Prostitution in Myanmar." Global Times. Accessed April 18, 2023.
[9] "Child Trafficking Statistics." World's Children, February 24, 2023.
[10] "Exploiting West Africa's Children: Trafficking, Slavery and Uneven Development." *Area* 37, no. 4 (2005): 393–401.
[11] "View the Latest Anti-Trafficking Statistics." Anti-Trafficking International, November 10, 2022.

don't have enough power to escape, and sometimes they don't know what is happening. Also, children may be afraid to ask for help. Additionally, traffickers are different between places. In the U.S. and other relatively rich countries, business owners and owners of farms or restaurants are likely to be traffickers because they are trying to maximize profit by reducing wages. In some poor countries, traffickers are always individuals and parents or family members because they want to give money by selling their children. A Chinese girl[12], Lien, was trafficked to the UK when she was 13. His aunt sold her to a man to earn money after Lien's parents died. Then he took her to the UK and left her at a brothel. Finally, he never came back.

However, some arguments talk about those children in poor areas having a low opportunity cost. A study sponsored by international organizations are tracing some children to see what happened to them after their dismissal: some were found working in more hazardous situations, in unsafe workshops where they were paid less, or in prostitution[13]. This study shows that because their family cannot support those children to get an education, their next alternative is either to stay at home or find other work.

Moyna, a ten-year-old orphan who has just lost her job, comments: "We are poor and not well educated, so they simply despise us. Girls usually stay at home, doing household work and looking after smaller children[14]." So, they have no choice other than to go to work. However, the problems in child labor trafficking are not discussed whether they can or cannot work, it is about whether they are or are not voluntary to work, which differentiates child labor from the issue of trafficked child labor. A poor child may be required to labor for the sake of monetary compensation, but that compensation is not provided when they are conned by traffickers and turned into slaves. Therefore, rent-seeking and ethical problems become crucial.

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[12] "HUMAN TRAFFICKING: MODERN DAY SLAVERY." *Socialist Lawyer*, no. 48 (2007): 12–16
[13] "The State of the World's Children 1997 - UNICEF." Accessed April 15, 2023.
[14] "Thank You, Mr Harkin, Sir!" New Internationalist, July 5, 2017.

Rent Seeking

Rent-seeking uses resources to take what an entity wants from others, so it transfers value without creating. However, the social cost of rent-seeking is higher, in the other words, this is a payment above opportunity cost. For example, back to Lien's case, the naïve net change for society is the money(M) that the man paid to her aunt and the man gains from the UK buyer which is -M+M=0. However, this formulation ignores rent-seeking. After Lien escaped, she said "I am very tired now, all the time, and I have very bad nightmares. I am still depressed. I think I always will be.[15]" She gains irreversible psychic trauma(T) from this case. And also there is an opportunity cost(C) that the trafficker (the man and UK's buyer) puts resources into time "finding victims" and the victim (Lien) puts resources into the years that she spent in the brothel. So, the true net change for society=-M+M-T-C=-T-C; the social cost of rent-seeking is T and C. Trafficking is a kind of rent-seeking because the victims are forced to work by violence, preventing them from leaving. Traffickers only "pay" maintenance costs to victims to maintain their life such as food and water. In Figure 1, the industry that traffickers engaged in can only hire Q1 workers at the market wage. However, the subsistence maintenance costs are lower than the market wage, so traffickers can now have Q2 workers. The blue area is the value lost to victims. So, trafficking transfers surplus from victims to traffickers.

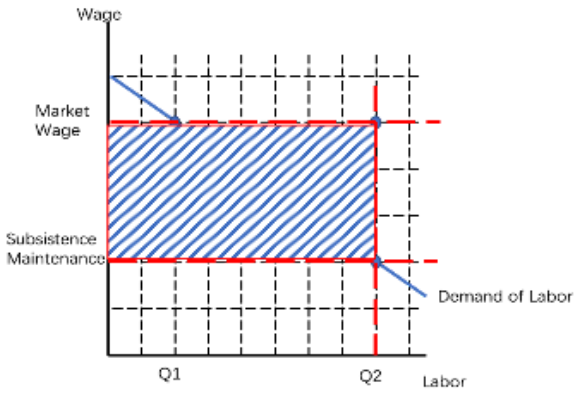

Figure 1

Moral problems

[15] "HUMAN TRAFFICKING: MODERN DAY SLAVERY." *Socialist Lawyer*, no. 48 (2007): 12–16.

In most labor trafficking cases, victims are forced to work by violating methods such as physical/emotional abuse, isolation, economic abuse, etc. Some utilitarianism is going to argue that even though we take something from those victims, our society gets much more economic profit using fewer resources. For example, Qatar spent $220 billion over 12 years to build 7 technologically advanced stadiums for the World Cups[16].

Utilitarianism considers sacrificing some utility of the forced workers is acceptable because the world has 7 amazing stadiums and Qatar has tons of travelers, so the total utility is increasing. However, profitable and economically effective are not equal to ethics. Robert Nozick, an American moral and political philosopher, discusses justice. He thinks if a trade satisfies 1) Property has been acquired without theft, fraud, or coercion, 2) Transfer of property occurs voluntarily, and 3) Property not conforming to 1& 2 is rectified through redistribution. Then, the market will create justice[17]. Using this theory in the labor trafficking "market", is not a justice one. First, the laborers have been frauded and coerced by the trafficker. And, the trading between traffickers, buyers, and victims is not totally voluntary. Even if the victims are from poor countries, they still have a reservation wage which is they want to participate in the labor market above that wage, so they cannot agree on work at a maintained cost, in other words, work for free. Overall, labor trafficking is inequality between individual choices and injustice for the victims.

What's the Data

It's not a question that labor trafficking is an issue not just domestically, but around the globe. However, many don't truly understand the scope to which it is a problem. Many see ads

[16]"Here's What Will Happen to Qatar's World Cup Stadiums Now." Time. Time, December 20, 2022.

[17] "The Entitlement Theory of Justice." *Contemporary Political Theory: A Reader*, 2004, 61–68.

on tv or on the internet that barely scratch the surface of the issue. What they don't know is the data, and how prevalent the issue is in today's world.

From a domestic perspective, it's estimated that more than 1,000 people are labor trafficked into the United States each year, according to the National Institute of Justice.[18] In total, experts believe there are between 100,000 and 300,000 total victims of labor trafficking in the U.S. alone, but there are unfortunately extremely large gaps in the data available. The Polaris Project, which operates the National Human Trafficking Hotline, estimates that more than twenty-five percent of all total victims are unknown, including their background, gender, and where they end up being trafficked to in the United States.[19]

With the data that we have available, we know that many of the known victims are migrants. More than 60% of identified victims were migrants, and 71% of those reported arrived in the U.S. on an H-2A or H-2B visa.[20] The Polaris Project has also noted that the plurality of known victims is of Latin American background, sitting around forty-seven percent, but in 2021 alone, when only looking at known victims, victims of Latin American background made up over eighty percent of victims.[21]

On a global stage, there are more than twenty million estimated victims of labor trafficking as of 2021, according to the International Labour Organization (ILO). In the ILO's September 2022 Global Estimate Study, researchers found that more than half of the world's victims of labor trafficking are exploited through the private sector, sitting around sixteen million

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[18] "Understanding and Characterizing Labor Trafficking among U.S. Citizen Victims." National Institute of Justice, April 25, 2022.

[19] "Polaris Analysis of 2021 Data from the National Human Trafficking Hotline." Polarisproject.org. Accessed April 18, 2023.

[20] "Polaris Analysis of 2021 Data from the National Human Trafficking Hotline." Polarisproject.org. Accessed April 18, 2023.

[21] "Polaris Analysis of 2021 Data from the National Human Trafficking Hotline." Polarisproject.org. Accessed April 18, 2023.

individuals.[22] They also found that more than four million alone are victims of forced labor via governments around the world. The ILO notes that fifty-four percent of victims are women and young girls, while almost twenty percent are children. In terms of where most victims are concentrated, Eastern Asia has the highest share of labor-trafficked victims, estimated to have around fifteen million people in forced labor. Eastern Asia also has the highest rate of labor trafficking per capita, estimated to be four per thousand individuals.

Who are the Traffickers

Traffickers are a complex part of the puzzle that is labor trafficking. The National Institute of Justice found in a 2016 domestic study that over two-thirds of identified traffickers were men in their late thirties and forties. They also found that "about half were U.S. citizens and half were noncitizens (either holding a nonimmigrant visa or unauthorized), but this varied across industries" (NIJ)[23]. In cases of agricultural trafficking, researchers found that over eighty-two percent of suspects were U.S. citizens, while in industries like hospitality, suspects were far more likely to be non-citizens. The study also delved into the organizational structures that traffickers operate under.

There are multiple different stages of trafficking itself, starting with recruitment and coercion, which is how traffickers and their partners seek to lure victims into opportunities for exploitation. The second stage is transportation, this is especially prevalent in operations with large numbers of victims such as farming or construction. This involves moving individuals from their original place of origin to either a place where an employer seeks to utilize trafficked labor or the traffickers themselves seek to move them to a new location to exploit them. The last stage

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[22] "Polaris Analysis of 2021 Data from the National Human Trafficking Hotline." Polarisproject.org. Accessed April 18, 2023.

[23] "How Does Labor Trafficking Occur in U.S. Communities and What Becomes of the Victims?" National Institute of Justice, August 31, 2016.

is more prevalent when a trafficker is a middleman or a seller of trafficked labor, reception or purchase happens when employers end up buying individuals from traffickers or exploiters involved in a large operation and receive trafficked laborers from people involved in their operations.

The NIJ found that industries like domestic servitude usually involved a single trafficker or a small group of traffickers, while large-scale operations like farming and construction involved sophisticated structures including recruiters, transporters, and management of the labor once they are transported and received. They also noted that traffickers often had very few "formal connections to other criminal networks, such as drug trafficking, weapons trafficking or money laundering. Some were involved in smuggling, document fraud, and sexual abuse" (NIJ)[24].

Who are the Victims

As noted before, many of the victims of labor trafficking are either migrants or domestic citizens who are already in poverty. They are often coerced or frauded into a state of modern slavery, and desperation drives their actions to accept false promises of a better life. They could be promised better-paying jobs abroad so they can support their families back home, they could be accepting the only job that would hire them, and then their employers utilize their power dynamic to abuse the laborer and keep them in a perpetual state of abuse.

Contrary to the mainstream idea of what a victim of labor looks like, the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services states that "Victims of labor trafficking are not a homogenous group of people. Victims are young children, teenagers, men and women. Some of them enter the country legally on worker visas for domestic, "entertainment," computer and agricultural work,

[24] "How Does Labor Trafficking Occur in U.S. Communities and What Becomes of the Victims?" National Institute of Justice, August 31, 2016.

while others enter illegally" (HHS).[25] Victims of trafficking can also be exploited because they have a form of mental disability, are underage, or are even kidnapped from their homes. Victims often end up in a different number of places, whether it be legal industries like farming or construction, or even illegal industries like the drug trade or gun-running operations.

Major Current Cases

Qatar

After Qatar won the right to host the 2022 World Cup in December 2010, its population grew rapidly between 2012 and 2013, with an increase of 10.5%, equivalent to an increase of about 20 people per hour. Many of Qatar's new hires come from South Asian countries. However, human rights groups have been critical of the country's treatment of foreign workers. In 2016, Amnesty International accused Qatari companies of forced labor[26]. Many workers live in squalid dormitories, are forced to pay exorbitant recruitment fees, and have their salaries withheld and passports confiscated[27]. Since 2017, the Qatari government has introduced measures to protect foreign workers from working in very hot temperatures, limit their working hours and improve worker accommodation.

However, a 2021 report by the advocacy group Human Rights Watch said foreign workers still suffer from "punitive and illegal wage deductions" and are "underpaid for long hours of heavy labor.[28]" In addition, the International Labor Organization has made statistics on labor fatalities during the Qatar World Cup project, and the data collected come from hospitals and emergency institutions operated by the Qatar government. According to the organization, in

[25] "Fact Sheet: Labor Trafficking (English)." The Administration for Children and Families. Accessed April 18, 2023.
[26] *Qatar: Abuse of World Cup Workers exposed*. Amnesty International. August 8, 2022, Retrieved April 20, 2023
[27] *World Report 2020: Rights Trends in Qatar*. Human Rights Watch. February 3, 2022, Retrieved April 20, 2023
[28] *"How can we work without wages?"*. Human Rights Watch. Retrieved April 20, 2023

2021 alone, 50 foreign workers will die, more than 500 will be seriously injured, and another 37,600 will suffer minor injuries[29].

Uyghurs in China

Another prominent example of labor trafficking is the Uyghur Muslim people who are currently being held in concentration camps in China. For about the last five years the Uyghurs people have been oppressed by the People's Republic of China (PRC) and are being forced to labor and are being starved and killed. The main reason for oppression is due to discrimination against their ethnicity and religion. The Chinese government captured and detained about a million people from the Uyghurs, ethnic Hui, ethnic Kazakhs, ethnic Kyrgyz, ethnic Tajiks, and ethnic Uzbeks and put them in 1,200 various work camps throughout China[30]. What makes this an interesting case of trafficking is the fact that the government is the one facilitating the trafficking of these citizens.

Now one may ask what is the purpose of these camps and what have these individuals done to be put in these camps? The answer is nothing but simply supporting their beliefs, and the People's Republic of China is trying to erase the culture and religion associated with these people. As a matter of fact, it has been revealed that China is not only committing mass genocide against these Uyghur individuals in their country but is even killing them to harvest their organs to sell in a booming transplant trade generating over $1 billion a year.[31] The world looks back on genocides such as the Nazi concentration camps with disgust and horror, yet at this very minute,

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[29] Occupational safety and health: ILO publishes reports on work-related deaths and injuries in Qatar. November 18, 2021. Retrieved April 20, 2023

[30] "Forced Labor in China's Xinjiang Region - United States Department of State." U.S. Department of State. U.S. Department of State, July 1, 2021.

[31] "Forced Organ Harvesting." Forced organ harvesting " world without genocide - making it our legacy. Accessed April 21, 2023.

these monstrosities are still occurring and the nation's media and citizens do not bat an eye, including the United States. This shows the importance of spreading information and being able to readily access information, as without worldwide education on these events, the world will continue to repeat its horrible mistakes.

Unique Cases

There have also been some very unique cases regarding labor trafficking domestically, further expanding the definition of what labor trafficking truly means. In September 2022, a woman from Meadville, Pennsylvania was charged with child labor trafficking as she was having foster children work for her car detailing business without compensation, and according to WFMJ slept on air mattresses inside the business and could only eat at designated meal times[32]. Some of these foster children were even children under her care, and it highlights just how expansive the definition of this crime can be and how close to home it can be. One could be getting their car detailed by what they believe to be a mother and her children, little do they know, the mother has her children living in inhumane conditions with no compensation for their work.

Similarly, in February 2022, 41-year-old South Carolina man Chris Smith was rescued after being a victim of labor trafficking at a local diner for 17 years. What is very interesting about the case of Chris Smith, was that he had a mental disability, and for this reason, was incapable of recognizing a way to escape from the terrible life he was in under the restaurant manager. According to the Post and Courier, Smith would be locked in the freezer and was afraid that the manager, Bobby Edwards, would kill him if he ever tried to escape[33]. This is yet another

[32] "Meadville Woman Arrested for Child Labor Trafficking." WFMJ.com. Accessed April 21, 2023.

[33] Hawesjhawes@postandcourier.com, Jennifer Berry, Awhitaker@postandcourier.com, Brandon Lockett/Staff, and Provided. "One SC Man's Journey to Freedom after Years in Modern-Day Slavery." Post and Courier, February 18, 2022.

instance of human trafficking happening right in everyone's backyard, as little could someone know, their morning breakfast was being cooked by a man in captivity for 17 years and being threatened with his life. Cases such as these highlight the importance of education on this subject, as the average first-world U.S. citizen with maximum access to education is unaware of the fact that labor trafficking is occurring in situations such as these, and fail to recognize just how often these events happen within their own country. This illustrates the importance of education regarding the prevention of this crime from occurring, as if first-world people are unaware of the dangers of trafficking, then third-world uneducated individuals have almost no chance of recognizing these dangers and can easily become the next victims.

Commonalities between societies

So how exactly can the present-day world go about solving such a complex issue? Well, it is critical to first take a look at the commonalities between societies that have had high levels of labor trafficking within their borders. Historically, between ancient societies such as Egypt, Greece, and Rome along with the United States, there were some major commonalities. Between them all, there was constant fighting and war between other nations throughout their development, requiring fast and efficient technological advancements. Additionally, severe discrimination and genocide amongst people who were foreigners were more prevalent throughout human history compared to the present day, making human trafficking socially acceptable at these times essentially everywhere.

Similarly, current-day nations have similarities in their operations as well. According to the Trafficking in Persons Report as of 2022, The top 10 countries in regard to labor trafficking are as follows: India, China, Russia, Uzbekistan, North Korea, Nigeria, Congo, Cambodia,

Thailand, and Malaysia[34]. Looking at these countries and their states of existence, there are many obvious similarities between these nations. For one, essentially all of these countries have very high poverty rates, with data from the World Bank reporting the poverty rate in Cambodia at 17.7%, India at 21.9%, Nigeria at 40.1%, and Congo at 73.8% with a poverty line of $1.90 per day[35]. North Korea as well falls in this category, with essentially almost its entire population being in poverty, but due to a lack of transparency, there is no reliable information regarding this nation. Additionally, these same countries have very high levels of uneducated people, with literacy rates of 74.4% in India, 78.4% in Congo, 63.9% in Nigeria, and 78.7% in Cambodia[36]. Clearly, there is a linear relationship between poverty and lack of education with human trafficking.

But what about the other 5 nations on the list? Their education levels and poverty rates are not below average, so what is similar between these 5 nations? Well, in fact, Russia, China, Uzbekistan, Thailand, and Malaysia all have a few things in common, and those are; the demand for cheap labor and corrupted/unstable/poor governance. Specifically, large economically profitable first-world countries such as the U.S., are the nations catalyzing this demand for cheap labor from external sources. In fact, The U.S. Census Bureau shows that in 2020 the total value of U.S. imports from China was $419.2 billion, Malaysia $27.4 billion, and Thailand $31.3 billion[37]. Due to the huge economic impact that the United States has on these nations' economies, along with their dense population densities, the value of human life plummets for the

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[34] "2022 Trafficking in Persons Report - United States Department of State." U.S. Department of State. U.S. Department of State, October 20, 2022

[35] Frédéric, POUMBOU, Haishan Fu, John Baffes, and Bo Pieter Johannes Andree. World Bank Open Data, April 20, 2023.

[36] "Literacy." UNESCO UIS, December 17, 2019.

[37] Bureau, US Census. "International Trade." United States Census Bureau, April 15, 2019.

sake of monetary profits. Similarly, nations like Russia and North Korea are both dictatorships, with Russia currently fighting a war. China, Russia, and Uzbekistan also have corrupt governments with terrible labor regulations, as can be seen with the Ughyurs in China, the extremely high Mob Crime presence in Russia along with almost no human rights laws by Vladimir Putin, and a state-controlled cotton sector known as "cotton slavery" in Uzbekistan. Also looking at historical societies, it was racial, gender, and income inequalities along with constant fighting and war which promoted the use of trafficked labor, further emphasizing this relationship between poverty, poor governance, and war with human trafficking.

Solutions

Therefore, looking at all of these similarities, it is clear what must be done by both the United States and the world as a whole in order to minimize this crime on humanity throughout the globe. First-world countries must begin to take action in these nations with high levels of poverty and low literacy rates at a much higher level than they are currently. Building and maintaining schools and providing teachers in these nations is paramount, along with even providing vocational and community-engaging programs. In this way, many of these countries can overcome their educational and discriminatory barriers over time, allowing people of all races, genders, and income levels to be able to access education. In this way, maybe one day individuals in nations such as Nigeria or the Congo could be taking a course equivalent to ECON 4597, learning directly about the dangers of labor trafficking, removing yet another potential victim.

But, this cannot just be done magically, as poverty will always get in the way of making this education sustainable at a beneficial level. For this reason, removing the vulnerabilities of potential victims is also crucial to curtailing this issue. Specifically, first-world nations need to

take actions such as making Trade Policies with these nations that benefit both sides, which can result in job creation and lower poverty rates in these nations. First-world nations could also provide even more financial aid to these countries, or actions such as providing access to their markets for goods or social safety nets. In this way, poor individuals can have greater access to goods, jobs, assistance programs, and overall social protection, allowing more people to go to school and fewer people to be in desperation.

Finally, the most difficult yet most important solution is to make human rights inalienable throughout the world. What makes this so difficult is the fact that the United States is one of the main participants in promoting the exact opposite, but theoretically, the United States could partner up with the EU and the OSCE and begin to promote good governance and human rights throughout the globe, providing diplomatic pressure and advocating democracy. Similarly, the United States and other economically dominant nations can impose stronger economic measures on these nations, such as trade and financial sanctions and restrictions. By doing so, nations who do not properly exercise human rights will have 1 of 2 choices, either suffer and lose the economic stimulation of favorable trading partners (similar to North Korea) or change their ways for the better of humanity. But, without the support of the United States government to cut off the cheap labor from Asia and take the negative impacts on their economy along with physical and monetary participation in global efforts, a global governing revolution will be difficult to progress towards.

Conclusion

In the end, the world must face a harsh reality; human trafficking is never going to completely go away, as its surplus will forever be too great to become essentially abolished in the global economy. Although this may be the case, the world must take action now to minimize

this activity as immensely as possible, as the current levels of trafficking in today's world are simply unsatisfactory and inhumane, with statistics that are appalling to read aloud. The key to lowering these statistics comes from greater access to education. In the current day world, it is very difficult to obtain any form of education when one comes from poverty, especially when one is not from a first-world nation. Even many wealthy individuals from first-world nations tend to not be aware of just how close to home and how expansive the trafficking industry truly is, with most believing that those things could "never happen to them".

But, although education is integral, education alone will not make a difference, but it is the key to a multi-faceted approach. With individuals that are more educated, citizens of nations where the laws are not humane/fair regarding labor will begin to recognize that they are not being given their unalienable human rights by their nation, and the people can take charge of their futures and make an impact on the future of their nations. It is education that could lead to political reform, another crucial aspect of solving this issue. As could be seen from both historical and modern-day examples of large-scale labor trafficking, it is the governments of these nations that catalyze the trafficking process, not only allowing it to exist but making it flourish.

The world needs unalienable human rights throughout its entirety, and it should be no excuse for nations to not intervene in nations that do not exercise these rights for their people, even though it may not be "within their jurisdiction". The United States loves to involve itself in other nations' business, so these actions wouldn't be too far off from what they are already doing, yet they would have an instrumental positive impact on humanity rather than the negatives they are currently causing. The United States needs to put aside its capitalist mindset

and realize that its demand for cheap labor is simply doing nothing else but exercising what was once U.S. slavery in other nations, “deflecting the blame” from themselves.

Finally, an overall better world where people are suffering less would result in less human trafficking. Due to poverty, war and income, gender, and racial inequality, many individuals in this world put themselves in vulnerable life positions, making them desperate and easy to coerce. A world with less suffering and desperation among the average person would in turn have a linear relationship with the amount of human trafficking occurring. All in all, humanity has done a relatively efficient job in learning from its history, and it should continue to take those measures for an issue as widespread as human trafficking before it is too late.

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